

from the nearest market that only 70 of the 200 families earmarked to move there went. In addition, people were unwilling to take up arms to defend their new homes.

Myths and realities

In September 1962, the regime announced that 4,322,034 people—33.39 percent of South Vietnam's population—were living in fortified settlements. By the end of the year, more than 6,000 such settlements were said to be in operation, with hundreds more under construction.

Some Americans high up in the Kennedy administration swallowed what Diem and Nhu were telling them. Roger Hilsman, the State Department's intelligence director, initially described the scheme as an effective strategic concept. Defense Secretary Robert McNamara believed the program showed that Diem was at last making progress in countering subversion.

The reality was very different. Many villagers bitterly resented being forced to labor unpaid, digging defensive moats, implanting bamboo stakes, and erecting fences to protect themselves against people who were not threatening them directly. The ones who agreed to join local self-defense groups became embittered when the modern weapons promised by the government failed to arrive in any quantity. Even Hilsman grew disillusioned when he visited South Vietnam on a fact-finding mission in 1963.

Corruption was endemic among the officials appointed to administer the program. Instead of distributing the money that had been earmarked to buy seed and fertilizer, and pay for irrigation schemes, schools, and medical care among the communities, they frequently embezzled it.